



Applying moisturizing creams to relieve dry, itchy skin, or ones recommended to reduce stretch marks, is safe during pregnancy.

Stretch marks (striae gravidarum) Many women develop stretch marks during pregnancy, which can occur on bellies, breasts, hips, or legs. These initially appear as pink or purple lines and may be quite itchy. After pregnancy they fade into pale wrinkles. Nobody knows for sure why these occur, but they probably result from a combination of pregnancy hormones and your skin stretching. You're more likely to get stretch marks if you're very young, if you gain a lot of weight in pregnancy, or if you have a very big baby. There is less agreement about the role of other factors such as a family history, being very overweight before pregnancy or belonging to a particular ethnic group.

Many creams, lotions, and oils have been marketed for the prevention or treatment of stretch marks but none has been proven to work. Studies performed on such products are inconclusive. Commercially produced creams, lotions, and oils are safe to use and may help to minimize stretch marks by maintaining the elasticity of the skin; unfortunately, however, there is no guarantee that they will prevent them.